

The Grape Guide

30 Essential Varieties — Characteristics · Regions · What You Need to Know

A one-stop reference for the grapes behind every wine in the Kazmi Cellars library. Each entry covers the grape's key characteristics, where it's grown, and the essential knowledge that will deepen your understanding of every bottle. kazmicellars.com

Red Grapes

Cabernet Sauvignon · Merlot · Pinot Noir · Syrah · Grenache · Tempranillo · Sangiovese · Nebbiolo · Malbec · Cabernet Franc · Zinfandel · Mourvèdre · Barbera · Gamay · Aglianico · Nero d'Avola

Cabernet Sauvignon

Cab Sauv · Cabernet

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Blackcurrant · Dark Cherry · Cedar · Tobacco · Graphite · Cassis · Mint (cool climate) · Leather (aged)

Key Regions

Pauillac / Médoc

Bordeaux, France

Coonawarra

South Australia

Margaux / Saint-Julien

Bordeaux, France

Maipo Valley

Chile

Napa Valley

California, USA

Stellenbosch

South Africa

What You Need to Know

The world's most planted fine wine grape and the backbone of the most age-worthy reds on earth. Thick skins produce high tannin; late ripening means it needs a warm climate. The green bell pepper note (pyrazines) signals underripe fruit — the goal is to ripen to pure cassis without raisining. In cool coastal sites (Saint-Julien, Margaret River) the wines are more herbaceous and structured; in warm inland sites (Napa Valley) they are richer and more concentrated. The tannins, which seem impenetrable when young, resolve over 10-30 years into extraordinary silky complexity. Pauillac — home to Lafite, Latour, Mouton Rothschild — is the spiritual capital of this grape.

Pairs with: Lamb · Beef · Duck confit · Hard cheese · Rack of lamb

Aging: Villages: 5-10 years. Classified Bordeaux /
Napa cult: 20-50+ years

Merlot

Right Bank Bordeaux

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Plum · Dark Cherry · Chocolate · Mocha · Blueberry · Bay Leaf · Spice · Velvety texture

Key Regions

Pomerol / Saint-Émilion

Bordeaux, France

Tuscany

Italy

Colchagua Valley

Chile

Washington State

USA

Napa / Sonoma

California, USA

Argentina

Multiple regions

What You Need to Know

The world's most planted red grape overall, and one of the most misunderstood. After the film *Sideways* (2004) caused US Merlot sales to crater, serious wine drinkers dismissed it — while quietly drinking Pétrus (nearly 100% Merlot, often the world's most expensive wine). The lesson: Merlot's approachability when young can mask its extraordinary potential when grown in the right soils. Pomerol's iron-rich clay amplifies Merlot's plummy richness into something of immense depth. Cheval Blanc in Saint-Émilion is majority Cabernet Franc + Merlot and one of the world's greatest wines. Thinner skins than Cabernet Sauvignon = lower tannin, more accessible young.

Pairs with: Roast beef · Duck · Pasta with rich sauces · Mushrooms · Braised meats

Aging: Most: 3-8 years. Best Pomerol / Saint-Émilion: 15-30+ years

Pinot Noir

Burgundy · Spätburgunder (Germany)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Red Cherry · Raspberry · Strawberry · Earth · Mushroom · Dried Leaves · Violet · Smoke (aged)

Key Regions

Côte de Nuits / Côte de Beaune	Burgundy, France	Yarra Valley / Mornington	Victoria, Australia
Willamette Valley	Oregon, USA	Champagne	France (blending)
Russian River Valley	Sonoma, USA	Baden / Pfalz	Germany — Spätburgunder
Central Otago / Marlborough	New Zealand		

What You Need to Know

The most finicky, most expensive, and most obsessively discussed red grape in the world. Thin skins mean low tannin, low colour, and extreme susceptibility to rot, disease, and temperature. It demands cool climates to develop complexity — too warm and it becomes jammy and character-less. More than any other grape, Pinot Noir is transparent to its terroir: the wines of Gevrey-Chambertin taste different from those of Chambolle-Musigny, which taste different from Vosne-Romanée, even though all three villages are within 5km of each other. DRC's Romanée-Conti — from a 1.8-hectare plot — produces roughly 6,000 bottles per year and sells for £10,000-£30,000+. The benchmark for what this grape can achieve.

Pairs with: Duck · Salmon · Mushroom risotto · Chicken · Veal · Coq au Vin

Aging: Most: 3-8 years. Burgundy Premier / Grand Cru: 15-30+ years

Syrah / Shiraz

Syrah (France/cool) · Shiraz (Australia/warm)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Black Pepper · Smoked Meat/Bacon · Olive · Blackberry · Dark Plum · Violets · Leather · Iron (cool climate)

Key Regions

Hermitage / Côte-Rôtie	Northern Rhône, France	Swartland	South Africa
Barossa Valley	South Australia	Mendoza	Argentina
McLaren Vale	South Australia	Crozes-Hermitage	Northern Rhône, France
Washington State	USA		

What You Need to Know

One grape, two personalities. Cool-climate Syrah (Northern Rhône) is peppery, savory, iron-mineral, and closed for years — it ages into something profound. Warm-climate Shiraz (Barossa) is rich, chocolatey, jammy, and hedonistic — designed for drinking with confidence. The black pepper aroma comes from the compound rotundone, which is highest in cool climates. Penfolds Grange — Australia's most iconic wine — is Shiraz-based and proved the New World could make reds that age like the Old World. Guigal's three single-vineyard Côte-Rôtie wines (La Mouline, La Landonne, La Turque) are considered the summit of the grape's potential in the Northern Rhône.

Pairs with: Lamb · Grilled meats · Game · Smoked meats · Hard aged cheese

Aging: Northern Rhône: 15-35+ years. Premium Barossa Shiraz: 10-20 years

Grenache

Garnacha (Spain) · Cannonau (Sardinia)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Red Berry · Strawberry · Kirsch · White Pepper · Garrigue · Dried Herbs · Leather · Tobacco

Key Regions

Châteauneuf-du-Pape	Southern Rhône, France	Sardinia (Cannonau)	Italy
Priorat	Catalonia, Spain	Barossa Old Vine	South Australia
Garnacha / Rioja	Spain	Roussillon	Southern France

What You Need to Know

The world's second most planted red grape. Usually the lead in Southern Rhône blends (GSM = Grenache-Syrah-Mourvèdre) but also capable of extraordinary solo performances. Château Rayas in Châteauneuf-du-Pape makes wine from 100% old vine Grenache that is considered one of France's greatest. Low natural acidity means it needs careful winemaking or blending to stay fresh. Naturally high alcohol (often 14-16%) from the hot, dry Mediterranean climate. Old vines (100+ years), especially in Priorat and Barossa, produce concentrated, structured wines from tiny yields. Álvaro Palacios's L'Ermita from Priorat is Spain's most expensive wine.

Pairs with: Roast lamb · Mediterranean dishes · Tapas · Charcuterie · Pizza

Aging: Most: 3-8 years. Old-vine Priorat / CdP: 10-20+ years

Tempranillo

Tinto Fino (Ribera) · Aragonez (Portugal) · Cencibel

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Dried Cherry · Plum · Tobacco · Leather · Vanilla (American oak) · Tomato · Dill (American oak) · Spice

Key Regions

Rioja	Northern Spain	La Mancha / Valdepenas	Central Spain
Ribera del Duero	Northern Spain	Alentejo (Aragonez)	Portugal
Navarra	Spain	Argentina	Various regions

What You Need to Know

Spain's most important red grape. The grape that defines Rioja's aging system — Crianza (2 years), Reserva (3 years), Gran Reserva (5+ years) — with the oak playing a starring role in shaping the wine's character. American oak was the traditional barrel type, giving a distinctive vanilla and dill character; French oak is now preferred in premium wines for a subtler influence. Vega Sicilia Único — aged up to 12 years before release — is Spain's most celebrated wine. Tempranillo translates as 'little early one' — it ripens earlier than many Spanish varieties, giving it natural freshness in a hot country.

Pairs with: Lamb · Roast pork · Suckling pig (Cochinillo) · Aged Manchego · Cured meats

Aging: Crianza: 3-5 years. Reserva: 5-12 years.
Gran Reserva: 10-25+ years

Sangiovese

Brunello (Montalcino) · Prugnolo Gentile (Montepulciano) · Morellino

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Sour Cherry · Dried Cherry · Tomato Leaf · Leather · Tobacco · Earth · Dried Rose · Balsamic (aged)

Key Regions

Chianti Classico	Tuscany, Italy	Morellino di Scansano	Tuscany, Italy
Brunello di Montalcino	Tuscany, Italy	Romagna	Emilia-Romagna, Italy
Vino Nobile di Montepulciano	Tuscany, Italy	Corsica (as Nielluccio)	France

What You Need to Know

Italy's most planted and most important red grape. High natural acidity is the defining characteristic — it gives Sangiovese its electric freshness and food-friendliness with Italian cuisine. Brunello di Montalcino (100% Sangiovese) is one of Italy's greatest age-worthy reds, released minimum 5 years after harvest and capable of aging 30-50+ years. The grape's acidity means it handles tomato-based foods better than almost any other red. Sassicaia — the Super Tuscan that changed Italian wine — is Cabernet Sauvignon-based rather than Sangiovese, but it triggered a reassessment of all Tuscan wines including Chianti Classico.

Pairs with: Bistecca alla Fiorentina · Tomato-based pasta · Pizza · Salumi · Hard aged cheese

Aging: Chianti Classico: 5-15 years. Brunello
Riserva: 20-40+ years

Nebbiolo

Barolo / Barbaresco · Spanna (Piedmont) ·
Chiavennasca (Valtellina)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Tar · Dried Rose · Sour Cherry · Tobacco · Leather · Licorice · Violets · Truffle (aged)

Key Regions

Barolo DOCG	Piedmont, Italy	Roero	Piedmont, Italy
Barbaresco DOCG	Piedmont, Italy	Valtellina DOCG	Lombardy, Italy
Langhe Nebbiolo	Piedmont, Italy		

What You Need to Know

'Tar and roses' — the two-word description that has defined Nebbiolo for a century. One of the most demanding grapes to grow and understand: almost undrinkable when young (the tannins are ferociously astringent), but after 15-20 years in bottle it becomes one of the most complex and ethereal wines on earth. So site-specific that it barely works anywhere outside Piedmont's Langhe hills. The divide between the 'traditionalists' (aged in large Slavonian oak for years, very tannic, built for decades) and 'modernists' (aged in smaller French barriques, more accessible young) defined Barolo's culture wars in the 1990s-2000s. Barolo is called 'the King of wines and the wine of Kings.'

Pairs with: Braised beef (Brasato al Barolo) · Truffle dishes · Aged Parmesan · Mushrooms · Osso Buco

Aging: Barbaresco: 10-25 years. Barolo: 15-40+ years. Doesn't reveal itself young.

Malbec

Côt (Loire/Bordeaux) · Auxerrois (Cahors) · Pressac

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Plum · Blackberry · Dark Chocolate · Violet · Leather · Coffee · Tobacco · Spice (oak)

Key Regions

Mendoza (Luján de Cuyo)	Argentina	Maipo / Colchagua	Chile
Uco Valley (high altitude)	Argentina	California	USA
Cahors AOC	Southwest France — original home		

What You Need to Know

Originally from Bordeaux and Southwest France (Cahors, where it's the lead grape), Malbec found its greatest expression in Mendoza, Argentina — particularly at high altitudes in the Uco Valley (900-1,500m). The intense UV radiation at altitude produces thick-skinned, deeply coloured grapes with a natural richness unlike anything possible in its French homeland. The Catena Zapata family pioneered high-altitude Malbec and put Argentine wine on the world map. Zuccardi Valle de Uco — named World's Best Winery three consecutive years — is the current benchmark for understanding what high-altitude Malbec can become. In Cahors it remains Cahors: dark, rustic, and a classic match for duck confit.

Pairs with: Beef (Argentine asado) · Lamb · Grilled meats · Empanadas · Duck confit

Aging: Most: 3-8 years. Premium single-vineyard: 10-20 years

Cabernet Franc

Breton (Loire) · Bouchet (Saint-Émilion) · Carmenet

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Raspberry · Cassis · Pencil Shavings · Violet · Green Herb · Tobacco · Dark Cherry · Blueberry

Key Regions

Chinon / Bourgueil / Saumur

Loire Valley, France

Argentina (Mendoza)

South America

Saint-Émilion / Pomerol

Bordeaux, France

Long Island

New York, USA

Friuli-Venezia Giulia

Italy

Wachau

Austria

What You Need to Know

The parent grape of Cabernet Sauvignon (crossed with Sauvignon Blanc). In the Loire Valley it stands alone as the great red grape of Chinon and Bourgueil; in Bordeaux's Right Bank it plays a crucial supporting role. Cheval Blanc — one of Bordeaux's most celebrated and expensive estates — is predominantly Cabernet Franc, proving its singular potential. More aromatic and less tannic than Cabernet Sauvignon, it is often described as 'the aromatic cousin.' The pencil-shavings and graphite character is distinctive and unmistakable. It ripens earlier than Cab Sauv, making it valuable in cooler climates where Cab Sauv struggles.

Pairs with: Duck · Pork · Mushroom dishes · Goat cheese · Charcuterie · Grilled salmon

Aging: Loire Valley: 5-15 years. Best Bordeaux (Cheval Blanc style): 20-40+ years

Zinfandel / Primitivo

Primitivo (Puglia, Italy) · Tribidrag (Croatia — ancestral origin)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Blackberry · Bramble Jam · Black Pepper · Raisins · Dried Fruit · Dark Spice · Leather · High Alcohol warmth

Key Regions

Dry Creek Valley / Sonoma

California, USA

Puglia (as Primitivo)

Southern Italy

Napa Valley

California, USA

Manduria / Taranto

Puglia, Italy

Lodi

California, USA

What You Need to Know

Genetically identical to Primitivo from Southern Italy and Tribidrag from Croatia — the grape originated on the Dalmatian coast and came to California via Italian immigrants. In California it became the quintessential American red: big, bold, high in alcohol (15-17%), and unashamedly generous. The high alcohol comes from the grape's tendency to ripen unevenly — some clusters become almost raisin-like while others remain fresh, so the finished wine has a layered sweetness. Ridge Vineyards' Geyserville (often a Zinfandel-dominant blend) and Lytton Springs are the benchmarks. White Zinfandel — a sweet rosé — is a completely separate product that unfortunately overshadows the serious red.

Pairs with: Barbecue · Grilled meats · Pizza · Spicy foods · Sausage · American cheeseburger

Aging: Most: 3-7 years. Best old-vine Dry Creek: 8-15 years

Mourvèdre / Monastrell

Monastrell (Spain) · Mataro (Australia/California)

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Meat / Game · Leather · Black Olive · Blackberry · Iron · Violet · Dark Plum · Garrigue

Key Regions

Bandol AOC Provence, France — the definitive home

Barossa / McLaren Vale

South Australia

Châteauneuf-du-Pape Southern Rhône, France

Paso Robles

California, USA

Murcia / Valencia (Monastrell) Spain

What You Need to Know

The M in GSM (Grenache-Syrah-Mourvèdre) blends. In Bandol, Provence, it stands alone and produces one of France's most structured, most long-lived, and most distinctly meaty red wines. Needs very warm conditions to ripen fully — when underripe it tastes gamey and unpleasant; when fully ripe it produces extraordinary complexity. Château Pibarnon and Domaine Tempier are the Bandol benchmarks. In Spain, Monastrell makes rich, dark, heady wines in Murcia — particularly in DO Jumilla and Yecla. The wine's deeply savory, gamey character makes it one of the great matches for grilled meats and game.

Pairs with: Game · Wild boar · Cassoulet · Lamb with herbs · Hard aged cheese · Charcuterie

Aging: Bandol: 10-25+ years. Most other regions: 5-12 years

Barbera

Barbera d'Asti · Barbera d'Alba

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Sour Cherry · Black Cherry · Blueberry · Herbs · Dried Plum · Spice · Fresh Red Fruit · No astringency

Key Regions

Asti DOC Piedmont, Italy

Monferrato

Piedmont, Italy

Alba DOC Piedmont, Italy

California (Italian heritage regions)

USA

What You Need to Know

Piedmont's everyday red grape — the one Piemontesi drink with Tuesday's pasta while saving Barolo for special occasions. Very high acidity and very low tannin is the defining combination: this makes it supremely food-friendly and makes it refreshing rather than austere. It lacks the grandeur of Nebbiolo but compensates with immediate, vivid fruit and the ability to pair with practically any Italian food. When aged in barrique (small French oak barrels), it takes on more depth and spice while retaining its essential character. Giacomo Bologna's Bricco dell'Uccellone (Asti) changed how the world thought about Barbera in the 1980s.

Pairs with: Pasta · Pizza · Antipasto · Lighter meats · Charcuterie · Almost any Italian food

Aging: Most: 2-5 years. Barrique-aged versions: 5-10 years

Gamay

Gamay Noir à Jus Blanc

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Fresh Cherry · Strawberry · Raspberry · Bubblegum (carbonic maceration) · Violet · Granite mineral · Banana (Nouveau)

Key Regions

Beaujolais (all 10 Crus) France — the definitive home

Switzerland (Dole blend)

Switzerland

Touraine / Loire

France

Ontario

Canada

Savoie

France

What You Need to Know

Beaujolais Nouveau — released each November — made Gamay internationally famous and then nearly destroyed its reputation by making the grape synonymous with cheap, inconsequential wine. The ten Beaujolais Crus (Morgon, Moulin-à-Vent, Fleurie, Brouilly, etc.) are entirely different: serious, terroir-driven wines with genuine aging potential. Morgon's decomposed granite soils give its Gamay a character sometimes compared to Burgundy Pinot Noir. The low tannin makes Gamay the benchmark chillable red — serve slightly cool (14-15°C) for best results. Carbonic maceration (used for Nouveau) extracts colour and fruit without tannin by fermenting whole bunches inside a CO2 environment.

Pairs with: Charcuterie · Chicken · Salmon · Light pasta · Cheese · Picnic food — endlessly versatile

Aging: Beaujolais Nouveau: drink immediately.
Crus (Morgon, Moulin-à-Vent): 5-15 years

Aglianico

'The Barolo of the South' · Aglianico del Vulture

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Dark Cherry · Dried Herbs · Iron · Leather · Tar · Dark Chocolate · Volcanic Ash · Tobacco

Key Regions

Taurasi DOCG

Campania, Italy

Irpinia

Campania, Italy

Aglianico del Vulture DOCG

Basilicata, Italy

What You Need to Know

One of Italy's most dramatically structured grapes — grown on the volcanic slopes of Mount Vesuvius (Taurasi) and Mount Vulture (Basilicata). The volcanic soils impart a distinctive iron-mineral, ashy quality to the wine. Ripens late — harvest often extends into November, well after the rest of Italy. When young, the tannins are fierce and the wine almost impenetrable. Given 10-15 years, it becomes one of the most profound and characterful reds in Italy. Taurasi Riserva DOCG requires minimum 4 years aging before release. The benchmark is Mastroberardino's Radici Riserva and Feudi di San Gregorio's Piano di Montevergine.

Pairs with: Lamb · Braised meats · Wild game · Aged Pecorino · Strongly flavored dishes

Aging: Needs minimum 5 years. Best examples:
15-30+ years

Nero d'Avola

Sicily's flagship red · Calabrese

Body



Tannin



Acidity



Alcohol



Key Flavors & Aromas

Dark Cherry · Chocolate · Dried Herbs · Licorice · Carob · Tobacco · Black Pepper · Sun-dried Fruit

Key Regions

Southeast Sicily (Avola, Pachino)

Sicily, Italy

Noto

Sicily, Italy

Ragusa

Sicily, Italy

What You Need to Know

Sicily's most important indigenous red grape, named after the town of Avola in the island's southeast. Makes wines ranging from easy-drinking, fruit-driven reds to serious, complex wines depending on the producer's approach and the site. The warm Sicilian climate gives it a natural richness and depth of colour. Producers like COS (biodynamic, amphora-fermented), Arianna Occhipinti (I.G.T., natural wine), and Gulfi (single-vineyard expressions) have elevated the grape's profile internationally. It often shows a distinctive Mediterranean character — carob, dried herbs, sun-baked earth — that reflects the island's landscape. One of the most food-friendly southern Italian reds.

Pairs with: Grilled meats · Rich pasta · Lamb · Aged Pecorino · Grilled vegetables · Arancini

Aging: Fresh styles: 2-5 years. Premium single-vineyard: 8-15 years

White Grapes

Chardonnay · Sauvignon Blanc · Riesling · Pinot Gris · Gewurztraminer · Viognier · Chenin Blanc · Albariño · Grüner Veltliner · Assyrtiko · Vermentino · Muscat · Furmint · Marsanne & Roussanne

Chardonnay

Chablis · White Burgundy · Pouilly-Fuissé

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Oak influence



Key Flavors & Aromas

Green Apple (unoaked) · Lemon / Citrus · Butter / Cream (oaked) · Hazelnut (aged Burgundy) · Peach (warm) · Pineapple (hot climate) · Toast (new oak) · Mineral (Chablis)

Key Regions

Chablis AOC	Burgundy, France	Yarra Valley / Adelaide Hills	Australia
Côte de Beaune (Meursault, Puligny)	Burgundy, France	Marlborough / Hawke's Bay	New Zealand
Champagne (blending)	France	Margaret River	Western Australia
Napa / Sonoma	California, USA		

What You Need to Know

The world's most planted white wine grape and the most malleable. In cool Chablis with its Kimmeridgian limestone soils, it is steel-and-oyster-mineral; in warm Napa Valley with heavy oak treatment, it is buttery and tropical — the same grape transformed almost beyond recognition by terroir and winemaking decisions. The oak-fermented, malolactic-converted (no sharp acidity), lees-aged version of Meursault and the cold-steel, unoaked Chablis are essentially different wines. The malolactic fermentation converts sharp malic acid (green apple) to soft lactic acid (cream/butter) — this is the winemaker's most consequential decision with Chardonnay.

Pairs with: White fish · Shellfish · Chicken · Pasta with cream sauce · Soft cheese · Veal chop

Aging: Most: 1-5 years. White Burgundy Grand Cru: 10-30+ years

Sauvignon Blanc

Blanc Fumé (Loire) · Fumé Blanc (California)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Grapefruit · Lime · Passion Fruit · Cut Grass · Gooseberry · White Peach · Elderflower · Smoke (Loire flint)

Key Regions

Sancerre / Pouilly-Fumé

Loire Valley, France

Constantia / Stellenbosch

South Africa

Marlborough

New Zealand

Casablanca / Aconcagua

Chile

Graves / Pessac-Léognan

Bordeaux, France

Friuli

Italy

What You Need to Know

The grape that single-handedly put New Zealand on the wine map when Cloudy Bay launched in 1985. The pyrazine compounds (same compounds in green bell pepper) create the characteristic grass and herb character — most intense in cool climates (Loire, Marlborough), almost absent in warm climates. In Bordeaux, barrel-fermented Sauvignon Blanc blended with Sémillon (Graves) can age magnificently for 20+ years — a completely different experience from the fresh, aromatic New Zealand style. Didier Dagueneau's Silex and Pur Sang from Pouilly-Fumé redefined what Sauvignon Blanc could achieve with minimal intervention and obsessive precision.

Pairs with: Goat cheese (classic) · Oysters · Seafood · Asparagus · Sushi · Green salads

Aging: Most: 1-3 years. Pouilly-Fumé / Sancerre: 5-8 years. Graves Blanc: 10-20+ years

Riesling

Most misunderstood great grape · Rhine · Mosel

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aging potential



Key Flavors & Aromas

Lime · Slate / Mineral · Green Apple · Petrol / Kerosene (aged) · White Peach · Apricot · Orange Blossom · Honey (late harvest)

Key Regions

Mosel Slate Valleys	Germany	Wachau (Riesling Smaragd)	Austria
Rheingau / Rheinhessen / Nahe	Germany	Finger Lakes	New York, USA
Alsace Grand Cru	France	Kamptal	Austria
Clare Valley / Eden Valley	South Australia		

What You Need to Know

The world's most misunderstood great grape. Most Riesling is dry or off-dry — not sweet — but the German Prädikat system (Kabinett, Spätlese, Auslese, Beerenauslese, Trockenbeerenauslese) confuses everyone. Ripens early, naturally very high acid, often only 7-10% alcohol in the best German versions. The 'petrol' or 'kerosene' aroma that develops after 5-10 years is from TDN compounds and is considered a mark of great Riesling, not a flaw. Egon Müller's Scharzhofberger Trockenbeerenauslese is one of the world's most expensive wines. The range of sweetness styles makes Riesling the most versatile food wine in existence: dry for seafood and pork; off-dry for spiced dishes; late harvest for desserts.

Pairs with: Spiced meats (Rogan Josh, tagine) · Seafood · Pork · Duck · Asian cuisine · Sushi

Aging: TBA / Auslese: 30-50+ years. Spätlese: 10-20 years. Dry Riesling: 5-15 years

Pinot Gris / Pinot Grigio

Grauburgunder (Germany) · Pinot Beurot (Burgundy)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Pear · White Peach · Honey · Almond · Spice (Alsace) · Lemon · Apple · Slight copper tint (skins)

Key Regions

Alsace Grand Cru	France — full-bodied, serious	Germany (Grauburgunder)	Germany
Friuli / Alto Adige / Trentino	Italy — light, crisp	Alsace (Vendange Tardive)	France — off-dry to sweet
Willamette Valley	Oregon, USA		

What You Need to Know

Two completely different wine experiences from the same grape, created by climate and winemaking philosophy. Italian Pinot Grigio — the world's most ordered restaurant white — is light, crisp, neutral, and refreshing. Alsatian Pinot Gris is rich, sometimes off-dry or lusciously sweet (Vendange Tardive), with the textural depth to match foie gras and rich charcuterie. The grape has pinkish-grey skins (gris = grey; grigio = grey) and occasionally shows a slight copper or salmon tint in the glass. Oregon Pinot Gris has carved its own identity — richer than Italian, leaner than Alsatian — and is one of the Willamette Valley's most successful white wines.

Pairs with: Italian style: antipasto, light fish, seafood. Alsace style: pork, foie gras, rich fish · French onion soup

Aging: Italian style: 1-2 years. Alsace Grand Cru: 5-15 years. VT: 10-25 years

Gewurztraminer

Traminer · Savagnin Rose

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Lychee · Rose Petals · Ginger · Exotic Spice · Jasmine · Orange Blossom · Honey · Turkish Delight

Key Regions

Alsace Grand Cru	France — the spiritual home	New Zealand	Gisborne region
Alto Adige / Tramin	Italy — ancestral origin	Pacific Northwest	Washington / Oregon, USA
Pfalz	Germany		

What You Need to Know

The most instantly identifiable white grape in the world — the lychee-rose-spice aroma is unlike anything else. The name means 'spicy grape from Tramin' — the village of Tramin (Termeno) in Alto Adige, Italy, is considered its ancestral home, though Alsace is where it truly flourishes. Low natural acidity makes it feel broad and slightly oily on the palate; the aromatics compensate. The best versions come from Alsace's Grand Cru sites — particularly Zind-Humbrecht's and Trimbach's. Vendange Tardive and Sélection de Grains Nobles versions are some of the world's most complex and age-worthy sweet whites. One of the great food-wine matches with intensely spiced dishes.

Pairs with: Foie gras (classic Alsace pairing) · Munster cheese · Rogan Josh · Moroccan tagine · Thai food · Peking Duck

Aging: Most: 3-8 years. Alsace Grand Cru / VT: 10-25 years

Viognier

Condrieu AOC (Northern Rhône)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Apricot · Peach · Tangerine · Honeysuckle · Jasmine · White Pepper · Marzipan · Blossom

Key Regions

Condrieu AOC	Northern Rhône, France — the definitive home	California (Central Coast)	USA
Château-Grillet	Northern Rhône — single-estate AOC	Eden Valley	South Australia
Languedoc-Roussillon	Southern France		

What You Need to Know

Nearly extinct in the 1960s — only 14 hectares of Condrieu remained. The wine world's intervention saved it, and today it is grown worldwide. The definitive version remains Condrieu: a tiny appellation producing wines of extraordinary floral intensity that justify their premium price. Viognier is famously co-fermented with Syrah in the best Côte-Rôtie wines — it adds aromatic perfume and stabilises the Syrah's colour through a chemical reaction. Low natural acid means it needs to be drunk relatively young or it becomes flabby and over-perfumed. When it works at peak — perfectly ripe, perfectly balanced — there is no more hedonistically beautiful white wine.

Pairs with: Lobster · Scallops · Foie gras · Roast chicken with herbs · Mild Asian dishes · Rich fish

Aging: Most: 1-4 years. Great Condrieu: up to 6-8 years

Chenin Blanc

Vouvray · Savennières · Steen (South Africa)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aging potential



Key Flavors & Aromas

Quince · Green Apple · Beeswax · Chamomile · Pear · Honey · Straw · Apricot (sweet versions)

Key Regions

Vouvray / Savennières	Loire Valley, France	California	USA
Anjou Blanc / Coteaux du Layon	Loire Valley, France	Argentina	Mendoza region
Swartland / Stellenbosch (Steen)	South Africa		

What You Need to Know

The most versatile white grape in the world — makes bone-dry mineral wines (Savennières), off-dry (Vouvray demi-sec), sparkling (Crémant de Loire), and some of the world's greatest sweet wines (Quarts de Chaume, Coteaux du Layon Sélection). The naturally very high acidity — which can taste aggressively sharp in young dry versions — gives it the structure to age for decades even in dry styles. South Africa has become its second great home: old-vine Chenin from Swartland (called 'Steen') produces wines of extraordinary complexity from bush vines planted 50-80 years ago. Nicolas Joly's Coulée de Serrant is the benchmark for dry Chenin Blanc.

Pairs with: Roast chicken · Pork · Hard cheese · Asian food · Smoked fish · Foie gras (sweet versions)

Aging: Dry: 5-20 years. Sweet botrytis versions: 30-50+ years

Albariño

Alvarinho (Vinho Verde, Portugal)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

White Peach · Apricot · Grapefruit · Saline / Sea Spray · Almonds · Lemon Zest · Floral · Slight bitterness (finish)

Key Regions

Rías Baixas DO Galicia, Spain — the home

Argentina

Mendoza region

Vinho Verde (Alvarinho subzone) Portugal

Australia

Recent plantings

California USA

What You Need to Know

The great white wine of Spain's rainy, green northwestern coast. Rías Baixas in Galicia sits on the Atlantic — the same latitude as northern Portugal and Brittany — and gets rain and ocean influence that is unique in Spain. The wines have a characteristic saline mineral quality that comes from the proximity to the sea. Thick skins protect the grape from the region's high humidity (disease pressure). The classic local pairing — Albariño with Galicia's magnificent seafood (pulpo, percebes, mariscos) — is one of the world's most intuitive food-and-wine matches. Has successfully transplanted to New Zealand, California, and Argentina.

Pairs with: Shellfish (the quintessential Galician pairing) · Octopus (pulpo) · Light fish · Sushi · Ceviche

Aging: Mostly 1-3 years; some premium versions 5+ years

Grüner Veltliner

GrüVe · Grüner · Austria's flagship white

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

White Pepper · Lime · Lemon · Green Herbs · Grapefruit · Mineral · Almond · Citrus zest

Key Regions

Wachau (Smaragd classification) Lower Austria — finest

Weinviertel DAC

Lower Austria

Kamptal Lower Austria

Moravia

Czech Republic

Kremstal Lower Austria

What You Need to Know

Austria's flagship white grape and one of the great underappreciated varieties. The white pepper note — from the compound rotundone — is so distinctive that it is Grüner Veltliner's fingerprint (the same compound responsible for Syrah's black pepper). The Wachau DAC has three quality tiers: Steinfeder (lightest, 11.5% max), Federspiel (medium, 12.5% max), and Smaragd (richest, named after the local emerald lizard — unlimited alcohol), which represents the finest, most age-worthy wines. Knoll, Hirsch, Bründlmayer, and Pichler-Krutzler are the benchmark producers. Has proven itself as the ideal accompaniment to asparagus (a notoriously wine-unfriendly vegetable).

Pairs with: Wiener Schnitzel (the Austrian pairing) · Asparagus · Sushi · Vegetable dishes · Light fish · Mushrooms

Aging: Most: 1-5 years. Wachau Smaragd: 8-15 years

Assyrtiko

Greece's greatest white · Santorini's soul

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Minerality



Key Flavors & Aromas

Lemon · Lime · Saline / Sea Brine · Volcanic Mineral · White Peach · Flint · Citrus Zest · Smoky

Key Regions

Santorini PDO	Greece — the definitive home	Macedonia	Northern Greece
Halkidiki	Northern Greece	Australia	Emerging plantings

What You Need to Know

Greece's greatest white grape and one of the world's most distinctive. Grown on the volcanic island of Santorini in basket-trained vines called 'kouloura' — the basket shape protects the grapes from the island's fierce winds. The volcanic pumice soils, the marine winds, and the ancient vines (some 70+ years old, ungrafted due to phylloxera's inability to survive in the volcanic soil) create a wine unlike any other in the world. Naturally very high acidity despite the Mediterranean sun — the winds and volcanic cooling maintain freshness. The 'Nychteri' style (fermented overnight, traditionally) is oaked and rounder; the standard version is electrifying, taut, and oceanic.

Pairs with: Grilled octopus · Oysters · Lobster · White fish · Feta cheese · Greek mezze · Bouillabaisse

Aging: Standard: 3-10 years. Nychteri (oaked): 8-15 years

Vermentino

Rolle (Provence, France) · Pigato (Liguria)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Lime · Grapefruit · White Peach · Almonds · Bitter Herb · Sea Brine · Floral · Slight bitter finish

Key Regions

Vermentino di Sardegna / Gallura DOCG	Sardinia, Italy — finest	Corsica (as Rolle)	France
Côtes de Provence (as Rolle)	France	Languedoc	Southern France
Liguria / Colli di Luni	Italy		

What You Need to Know

The Mediterranean coast's signature white grape — saline, bitter, herbaceous, and mineral in the finest expressions. Vermentino di Gallura DOCG from northern Sardinia's granite plateau is the benchmark: wines of distinctive saline-mineral intensity that reflect the island's rugged landscape. The slight bitterness on the finish is characteristic and is considered a quality marker, not a flaw — much like the bitterness in a great espresso. In Provence it is called Rolle and is typically blended into Provençal whites and rosés. One of the best wines for Mediterranean seafood dishes.

Pairs with: Seafood · Clams (Vongole) · Mussels · Grilled fish · Bouillabaisse · Pesto pasta

Aging: Most: 1-3 years. Gallura DOCG premium versions: 4-7 years

Muscat / Moscato

Muscat Blanc à Petits Grains · Moscato d'Asti · Muscat d'Alsace

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aromatic intensity



Key Flavors & Aromas

Fresh Grape · Rose Water · Orange Blossom · Lemon · White Peach · Apricot · Honey · Orange Zest

Key Regions

Asti / Piedmont (Moscato d'Asti)

Italy — gently sweet, effervescent

Samos

Greece — sweet

Alsace (Muscat d'Alsace)

France — bone dry

Rutherglen

Victoria, Australia — intensely sweet, aged

Beaumes-de-Venise

Southern Rhône, France — sweet

What You Need to Know

The only great white grape that smells like fresh grapes in the glass — all other varieties smell of transformation. The Muscat family includes hundreds of varieties; the finest is Muscat Blanc à Petits Grains ('small white grapes'). Makes wines at every sweetness level: bone dry in Alsace, gently sweet and low-alcohol (5.5%) in Moscato d'Asti, fortified and sweet in Beaumes-de-Venise, and extraordinarily concentrated in Rutherglen's aged 'Topaque and Muscat' (a solera-aged system that can be 50+ years old). Moscato d'Asti is Italy's most popular dessert wine — served in small glasses after a meal, it is a perfect ending.

Pairs with: Fruit desserts · Light pastries · Prosciutto (sweet-salt match) · Mild cheese · Aperitivo

Aging: Mostly drink young. Rutherglen Muscat: indefinitely. Beaumes-de-Venise: 5-15 years

Furmint

Tokaji · Tokay (Hungary)

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aging potential



Key Flavors & Aromas

Lime · Green Apple · Smoke · Ginger · Saffron (aged Tokaji) · Apricot (sweet) · Honey · Caramel (aged sweet)

Key Regions

Tokaj wine region

Hungary — the definitive home

Burgenland

Austria

Badacsony / Somló

Hungary

Slovakia

Tokaj cross-border region

What You Need to Know

Hungary's most important white grape and the foundation of Tokaji Aszú — one of the world's great sweet wines, praised by Louis XIV, Catherine the Great, and Voltaire. Furmint's naturally very high acidity gives Tokaji the structure to age for centuries — documented bottles from the 18th and 19th centuries are still vibrant. The famous Aszú production uses botrytis-affected berries ('aszú berries'), individually picked by hand, measured in 'puttonyos' (buckets — 3 to 6, the more the sweeter). Today Furmint is also made as a dry wine of extraordinary complexity and age-worthiness. Royal Tokaji and Disznókő are the leading producers.

Pairs with: Foie gras (sweet Tokaji — one of the great pairings) · Blue cheese · Dry Furmint with fish · Desserts

Aging: Sweet Tokaji Aszú: 30-100+ years. Dry Furmint: 5-15 years

Marsanne & Roussanne

Hermitage Blanc · Saint-Joseph Blanc ·
Crozes-Hermitage Blanc

Body



Acidity



Sweetness



Aging potential



Key Flavors & Aromas

Almond · White Flowers · Marzipan · Apricot · Beeswax (Marsanne aged) · Peach · Lanolin · Herb (Roussanne)

Key Regions

**Hermitage /
Crozes-Hermitage (white)**

Northern Rhône, France

Languedoc

Southern France

Saint-Joseph (white)

Northern Rhône, France

Savoie (Marsanne)

France

**Châteauneuf-du-Pape
(white blend)**

Southern Rhône, France

What You Need to Know

The two great white grapes of the Northern Rhône, typically blended together into wines of remarkable richness and longevity. Marsanne is heavier, richer, and ages into waxy, honeyed, almond-blossom complexity — almost paradoxically, it can taste less interesting young than it does at 15-20 years. Roussanne is more aromatic, more fragile, and more floral. Jean-Louis Chave's Hermitage Blanc — a blend of both — is considered one of France's greatest white wines, capable of aging 30+ years. Often misunderstood as 'lesser' grapes because they are less internationally planted than Chardonnay — the finest examples from Hermitage are among the world's most profound whites.

Pairs with: Roast chicken · Lobster · Sea bass · Foie gras · Goat cheese · Rich fish preparations

Aging: Marsanne (Hermitage): 15-30+ years.
Roussanne: 8-20 years. Most others: 3-8 years